

Even More Visual

For a graphical representation of your PivotTable, you can use PivotCharts—you can either create both the PivotTable and PivotChart from the Insert tab > PivotTable button, or you can generate a PivotChart from an existing PivotTable in the Options tab under the PivotTable Tools.

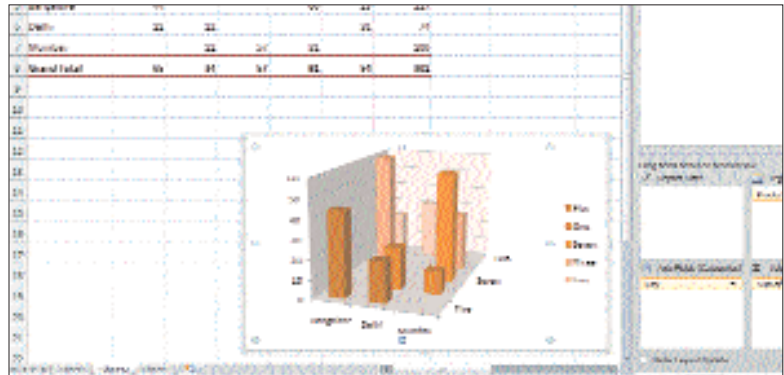
More often than not, you'll find the 3D charts more useful to represent data. Column fields are now Legend fields (they'll be represented in different colours), Row fields are now Axis fields (they'll be represented as the X and Y axis), and Value fields remain the same (they'll be represented along the Z axis). Moving these fields around will also cause your PivotTable to rearrange itself. Getting PivotCharts to work right can be tricky business, especially if you have too many axis fields.

Little Things

When you start dragging fields to create the PivotTable, Excel updates your view in real time. If you're working with copious amounts of data, this can become a real burden on your system, especially if you're experimenting with different layouts. The best way to avoid this is to use the little "Defer Layout Update" checkbox at the bottom of the Field List, and click the Update button only when you're ready to see how your new layout looks.

When you update any data in the source table, you need to manually refresh the PivotTable for the change to get reflected, so it's

better if you generate the PivotTable after you're done making changes to the source table—forgetting to refresh the PivotTable can lead to erroneous reports. The best way to avoid this is to write a macro that refreshes the PivotTable every time the source table is updated.



The PivotChart is a graphical version of your PivotTable

Endnote

The only trouble with PivotTables is that you never *really* know whether it applies to your data, which is probably why most people avoid it.

As you've seen, though, they're very simple to understand, and the best way to find out if it applies to you is to try it—you might have your answer in as little as half an hour! ■

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my own
network
manager

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